Case Study: Instacart agent-readiness product

You are product lead in a product consulting firm that helps companies rewrite their software so that both autonomous AI agents and humans can use it well. The company's working thesis is within the next 12 months, agents will begin acting on behalf of users at scale — comparing, ordering, cancelling, adjusting — often without a person reviewing every step.

Instacart is being rewritten to be "agent-ready" — so that a user's AI assistant (not Instacart's, assume something like an agent that shipped with the user's phone) can place a weekly grocery order, handle substitutions, manage a recurring list, and make judgment calls within boundaries the user has set, the way a trusted personal shopper would.

You are the Product Lead on this engagement.

The Questions

Please analyse the following scenarios and record your responses.

1. Make the case for why groceries are a *good* place to start

2. Instacart's own product team wants to prioritize a flashier feature for a board demo in six weeks, even though you believe it'll be thrown out in three months once real agent traffic hits it and exposes its flaws. Will you build what they asked for or push back and delay?

3. You have 2 engineers and 4 weeks. You can make the checkout API agent-readable, or the substitution-preference API agent-readable. Which one will you pick.?

4. Two different agent platforms integrate with the new Instacart API/MCP and interpret an ambiguous field ("quantity: 2") differently — one orders 2 units; one orders 2 packs of wheat - 1Kg. Where could be this problem be? And how will you fix?

5. Agents placing orders on behalf of users would increase the orders but there may be complaints that "users didn't mean to place the order" and there's no historical data for agent-initiated purchases. What should be the threshold of orders per user per month and why this threshold?

6. A competitor's agent-readiness project at a different grocery buying app stalls publicly after four months — bad press, a client blaming the consulting team. Your

Instacart contact asks you, point blank, "should we be worried, this will happen to us?", What will you say, your project is facing uncertainty?

Please share the responses as PDF file.